

Unstoppable: Gulveer Singh completed a golden double in the 5000m and 10,000m. **Middle:** 18-year-old Pooja became the youngest Asian champion from India in high jump, setting two personal bests along the way.

But by the end, they were all worried — even Arshad. I was watching from the stands, and *uske chehre se pata lag raha tha ki usko kuch samajh nahi aa raha tha* (from his face you could tell he didn't know what was going on)," he says.

As the reigning Olympic javelin champion, Arshad had swaggered into Gumi expecting to coast to the title, only to end up trailing Sachin for the first three throws of the competition. He eventually pulled ahead on his fourth attempt, eking out a fairly narrow win with a throw of 86.40m. Sachin threw 85.16m — a new personal best.

While the Indian's performance may have fallen just short of pulling off a monumental upset, the fact that he showed no fear on the biggest stage of his career bodes well for the future.

Sachin admits as much: "Initially, my body was a little tight, but after a couple of throws, I was confident I could get the throw I wanted. It doesn't matter who I'm competing with — the only thing I think about is doing my best."

With 24 medals overall — 8 gold, 10 silver, and 6 bronze — India returned with its best-ever haul at an Asian Athletics Championships held overseas. But beyond the numbers, it's the composure and maturity shown by the country's next generation of athletes that stands out as perhaps the most significant takeaway.

Sachin wasn't the only first-time Asian Championship competitor to step up on the big stage. On the final day of the competition, 21-year-old Animesh Kujur (**right**) shattered his own national record by 0.18 seconds, clocking 20.32 to win bronze in the men's 200m — becoming only the second Indian in 52 years to medal in the event at the Asian Championships.

